

BUSAYO AWOBADE

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Lagos, NG

RESEARCH INTEREST

Research Engineer with over 3 years of experience developing algorithms and conducting applied machine learning research. My interests include low-resource NLP, speech processing, efficient ML, and multimodal systems. I aim to contribute to impactful research that advances AI accessibility, especially for low-resource communities worldwide.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science in Computer Science, Federal University of Agriculture, Abeokuta 2017 - 2023
Deeplearning.ai: Neural Networks and Deep Learning, Structuring Machine Learning Projects, Convolutional Neural Networks, Sequence Models;

PUBLICATIONS

- **Busayo Awobade**, ..., Tobi Olatunji. *AfriVox-v2: A Domain-Verticalized Benchmark for In-the-Wild African Speech Recognition*. Interspeech 2026.
- **Busayo Awobade**, ..., Tobi Olatunji. *AfriVox: Probing Multilingual and Accent Robustness of Speech LLMs..* EACL 2026.
- Gabriel Zencha Ashungafac, Mardhiyah Sanni, **Busayo Awobade**, Alex Gichamba, Tobi Olatunji. *AfriSpeech-MultiBench: A Verticalized Multidomain Multicountry Benchmark Suite for African Accented English ASR*. IJCNLP-AAACL 2025.
- Chris Emezue, NaijaVoices Community, **Busayo Awobade**, et al. *The NaijaVoices Dataset: Cultivating Large-Scale, High-Quality, Culturally-Rich Speech Data for African Languages*. InterSpeech 2025.

PREPRINTS & WORKSHOP PAPERS

- Mardhiyah Oduwole, ..., **Busayo Awobade**, et al. *The Role of Data Augmentation in African Machine Translation*. LM4UC (AAAI) 2026
- **Busayo Awobade**, Mardhiyah Oduwole, Steven Kolawole. *What Happens When Small Is Made Smaller? Exploring the Impact of Compression on Small Data Pretrained Language Models*. AfricaNLP (ICLR) 2024.

EXPERIENCE

Research Scientist | Intron

Nov. 2024 - Present

- **Engineered a production-grade, multispeaker TTS model** supporting 13 African languages and 10 regional accents, utilizing data pipelines capable of processing noisy, in-the-wild audio and legacy ASR corpora.
- **Architected an end-to-end data pipeline** to scrape and preprocess 35K+ hours of conversational and in-the-wild speech, featuring a custom chunking algorithm optimized for 24 African languages.
- **Designed a language-agnostic benchmarking framework** to rigorously evaluate multimodal and unimodal ASR models on both read, conversational and in-the-wild African speech data.
- **Spearheaded the AfriVox Benchmark**, a comprehensive, verticalized ASR and AST evaluation suite spanning 24 African languages, published for open research use.

Research Engineer | Babs

Jan. 2024 - Jun. 2024

- Trained and evaluated **TTS models** for 3 African languages (**Yoruba, Swahili, and Hausa**) using the **VITS architecture** on publicly available African speech corpus.
- Extended **Meta's MMS model** to produce better natural sounding Yoruba and Hausa speech using the common voice aligned corpus.

- Led the research on **speech-to-speech translation with expressivity transfer** which followed Meta's Seamless Expressivity work.
- Built a **cascaded speech-to-speech translation system** using ASR (**whisper**), TTT (**m2m100**) and expressive TTS model, **Bark**.

Research Scientist | MLCollective

Nov 2023 - Present

- Leading the research team for the local chapter (Nigeria); Helping young research enthusiast find their footing in ML research.
- Moderating talk sessions, meetups, presentations, and webinars on NLP.

Founding Machine Learning Engineer | ASALytics (now NazariAI)

Mar. 2022 - Dec. 2022

- Awarded **\$115k grant** in funding from the Algorand Foundation to build the **ASALytics** platform;
- Set up **CI/CD pipeline** for model and application server using **GCP cloud build** and **GCP cloud run**.

Data Science, Intern | Zummit Info Labs

June. 2021 - Oct. 2021

- Built an object detection model to detect and classify road traffic signs using a **yolo** model coupled with a deep learning classifier to correctly classify detected traffic signs according to their respective classes for autonomous vehicles.
- Trained a race detection model for a machine learning system that detects racial profiling and racial bias amongst airport security using Google's **FaceNet** to generate face embeddings passed into a **Lightgbm** classifier.

PROJECTS & AWARDS

Algorand Foundation Grant Award - Algorand Foundation

- Awarded **\$115k** to build an opinion mining platform for the algorand ecosystem. (2022)

Best Poster Awards - Deep Learning Indaba

- Won best poster awards at the 2023 Deep Learning Indaba for **What happens when small is made smaller?**.

Omdena Communities

- Led the machine learning team for the Columbia community to build a multilingual **bertTopic** model for both Spanish and English topic generation on tweets/reddit posts to monitor the 2021 Columbia nationwide project. (2021)
- Using **Yolo-v5**, **docker** and **AmazonEC2**; built a machine learning solution to speed up (**2x**) tea-leaf processing for the Sri-Lanka Tea industry. (2021)

DSN Data Science Hackathon - Data Scientist Network

- Finished **1st placed runner-up** amongst 750 skilled Data scientist at the DSN nationwide hackathon. (2020)

UmojaHack Africa - Umoja, Kenya

- Led my university to a **3rd runner-up finish as the 4th best AI university in Nigeria in 2021**.

AXA Nigeria 2020 Hackathon - AXA Mansard

- Led my university to a **5th place finish** at the AXA-Mansard Insurance claim hackathon. (2020)

VOLUNTEER ACTIVITIES

- Peer Reviewer AfricaNLP@ICLR '24, EMNLP '23, TinyPapers@ICLR '23.
- Co-organizer; Masakhane's EfficientNLP workshop at Deep Learning Indaba 2023.
- Ex-lead for the AI community at Federal University of Agriculture, Abeokuta;